

Apostolic Succession Denial

doc-apostolic-succession-denial

Leadership & Polity · Ordination · doctrine · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

Supported across the whole Bible

Subject named directly in

Scripture

Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Apostolic continuity in the Church is grounded in fidelity to the apostles' teaching rather than in the unbroken transmission of episcopal office through the laying-on of hands.

In plain language

This statement says the Church stays linked to the apostles by holding to their teaching, not by an unbroken chain of bishops passing on office through the laying-on of hands. The original-language evidence cuts in two directions, which is why the result is marked disputed. On one side, the picture of a foundation is strong. In Ephesians 2:20 believers are spoken of with a past-tense verb 'having been built upon' (epoikodomethentes), set on the 'foundation' (themelios) of the apostles and prophets, with Christ as the 'cornerstone' (akrogoniaios). In First Corinthians 3:11 Paul says flatly that 'no one' (oudeis) is able to 'lay' (theinai) any other foundation than the one already in place, Jesus Christ. Revelation 21:14 even fixes the apostolic 'foundations' (themelios) at twelve, named. And what made someone an apostle looks one-time: Acts 1 requires a man who had been with Jesus and saw him risen, a 'witness' (martys) of the 'resurrection' (anastasis); Paul defends himself by saying 'I have seen' (heoraka, a past seeing whose result still stands) the Lord; and he calls himself the 'last of all' (eschaton) to whom the risen Christ appeared. A seeing that has a last member is a closed set, not a line that continues. On the other side, the same writings clearly use a hands-on rite. A 'gift' (charisma) is given through the 'laying on' (epithesis) of hands in First Timothy 4:14 and Second Timothy 1:6, hands are not to be laid hastily, and elders are 'appointed' (kathistemi) city by city in Titus 1:5 and 'appointed by hand-raising' (cheirotoneo) in Acts 14:23. Second Timothy 2:2 tells Timothy to 'entrust' (parathou) what he heard to 'faithful' (pistois) men who can teach others, a real chain. So the words plainly support passing on the teaching and a genuine ordination, but here is the crux: when the texts describe the laying-on of hands, the thing handed over is called a 'gift' (charisma) for service and an office of 'elder' (presbyteros) or 'overseer' (episkopos), never the word 'apostle' (apostolos), and the thing that makes an apostle, seeing the risen Lord, is never tied to a rite. The vocabulary therefore does not tell us whether ordination passes on apostolic authority itself or only ongoing ministry. That gap, not any outside opinion, is why careful readers land on different answers.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0204	ἀκρογωνιαίος	akrogoniaios	cornerstone	2
G0243	ἄλλος	allos	another	171
G0386	ἀνάστασις	anastasis	resurrection	42
G0450	ἀνίστημι	anistēmi	to arise	
G0645	ἀποσπάω	apospao	to draw away	4

G0652	ἀπόστολος	apostolos	apostle	79
G1294	διαστρέφω	diastrepho	to pervert	7
G1321	διδάσκω	didaskō	to teach	
G1410	δύναμαι	dynamai	be able	211
G1936	ἐπίθεσις	epithesis	laying on	4
G2007	ἐπιτίθημι	epitithemi	to put/lay on	39
G2026	ἐποικοδομέω	epoikodomeo	to build up/upon	7
G2078	ἔσχατος	eschatos	last/least	52
G2310	θεμέλιος	themelios	foundation	16
G2525	καθίστημι	kathistemi	to appoint/conduct	22
G2749	κεῖμαι	keimai	to lay/be appointed	25
G2980	λαλέω	laleō	to speak	
G3101	μαθητής	mathetes	disciple	275
G3144	μάρτυς	martys	witness	35
G3708	ὁράω	horao	to see	668
G3762	οὐδείς	oudeis	none	248
G3860	παραδίδωμι	paradidomi	to deliver	121
G3866	παραθήκη	paratheke	deposit	3
G3908	παρατίθημι	paratithemi	to set before	19
G4102	πίστις	pistis	faith	
G4103	πιστός	pistos	faithful	67
G4244	πρεσβυτέριον	presbuterion	council of elders	
G4245	πρεσβύτερος	presbuteros	elder	
G4396	προφήτης	prophetes	prophet	149
G5087	τίθημι	tithemi	to place	100
G5486	χάρισμα	charisma	gift	17
G5495	χεῖρ	cheir	hand	
G5500	χειροτονέω	cheirotoneo	to appoint	4

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Direct queries confirm the original-language pattern lands on both sides of this proposition, which is why it is disputed rather than settled. The foundation half is strong: Ephesians 2:20 builds believers with the verb 'having been built upon' (epoikodomethentes, an aorist passive participle, that is, a completed past action in the passive voice) on a single 'foundation' (themelios) of apostles and prophets, with Christ the 'cornerstone' (akrogoniaios), and 1 Corinthians 3:11 says 'no one' (oudeis) 'is able' (dynatai, present indicative, that is, an ongoing, simple statement of fact) to 'lay' (theinai, aorist infinitive of tithemi, the form for a completed past action) 'another' (allon) foundation than the one already 'laid' (keimenon), so the base is fixed once. The apostle's own qualification also looks non-repeatable: Acts 1:21-22 requires one who 'accompanied' the disciples (synelthonton) and is a 'witness'

(martys) of the 'resurrection' (anastasis), 1 Corinthians 9:1 grounds apostleship in the perfect-tense 'I have seen' (heoraka, a completed action whose result still stands), and 1 Corinthians 15:8 calls Paul 'last' (eschaton), last of all. But the canon also transmits and appoints: 2 Timothy 2:2 commands 'entrust' (parathou, an aorist middle imperative of paratithemi, that is, a one-time command to entrust as one's own act) the deposit to 'faithful men' (pistois), Jude 3 calls the faith 'once delivered' (hapax paradotheise), and the hand-laying vocabulary is real and effective, with 'gift' (charisma) given 'through the laying on of the hands' (dia epitheseos ton cheiron) in 1 Timothy 4:14 and 2 Timothy 1:6, with 'appoint' (kathistemi) installing elders in Titus 1:5 and 'appoint by hand-raising' (cheirotoneo) in Acts 14:23. The words establish succession of teaching and a genuine ordination rite, but they do not, by their original-language meanings, rank whether that rite conveys the foundational apostolic authority itself or only ongoing teaching office, so the proposition's exclusive contrast is underdetermined (the words leave the scope open).

Scripture

Eph.2.20 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2310 θεμέλιος, G0652 ἀπόστολος, G0204 ἀκρογωνιαίος, G2026 ἐποικοδομέω, G4396 προφήτης

Reasoning. Believers are described with the verb 'having been built upon' (epoikodomethentes, an aorist passive participle, that is, a completed past action in the passive voice, parsed -APPNPM-, meaning the verb form is participle, aorist, passive, nominative, plural, masculine), set on the 'foundation' (themelios) of the apostles and prophets, with Christ Jesus himself being the 'cornerstone' (akrogoniaios, in the from-X grammatical form known as the genitive). The completed-past participle and the single 'foundation' (themelios) frame the apostolic foundation as a completed, once-laid base of the building, not a status handed on repeatedly. The 'cornerstone' (akrogoniaios) is Christ, the controlling reference point of the whole structure.

1Cor.3.11 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2310 θεμέλιος, G3762 οὐδεὶς, G1410 δύναμαι, G5087 τίθημι, G2749 κεῖμαι, G0243 ἄλλος

Reasoning. Paul writes that 'no one' (oudeis) 'is able' (dynatai, present indicative third person singular, that is, an ongoing, simple statement of fact in the form 'he/she/it is able') to 'lay' (theinai, aorist active infinitive of titheimi, that is, the 'to-do' form for a completed past action) 'another' (allon) 'foundation' (themelios) besides the one already 'laid' (keimenon, present middle participle, that is, an ongoing-state participle of keimai meaning 'lying in place'), which is Jesus Christ. The exclusive negation 'no one' (oudeis) joined with the ongoing-state participle 'lying in place' (keimenon) presents the foundation as a fixed, accomplished reality centered on Christ, ruling out any later re-founding. The construction supports a singular, non-repeatable apostolic foundation.

Acts.20.30 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0450 ἀνίστημι, G2980 λαλέω, G1294 διαστρέφω, G0645 ἀποσπάω, G3101 μαθητής

Reasoning. Paul foretells that from among the elders themselves men will 'rise up' (anastesontai) speaking 'distorted things' (diestrammena, perfect passive participle of diastrepho, that is, a completed action whose result still stands, in the passive voice) to 'draw away' (apospan) the 'disciples' (mathetes) after them. The warning that corruption can emerge from within the ordained eldership cuts against any guarantee attached to office or lineage itself and foregrounds fidelity of teaching as the safeguard rather than positional standing.

Acts.1.22 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G3144 μάρτυς, G0386 ἀνάστασις

Reasoning. In choosing one to fill the apostolic number, the requirement (Acts 1:21-22) is a man who 'accompanied' the others (synelthonton, aorist participle of synerchomai, that is, a completed past-action participle meaning 'having come together with') the whole time the Lord moved among them and who becomes a 'witness' (martys) of the 'resurrection' (anastasis). The qualification is firsthand presence with Jesus and eyewitness of the risen Christ, which is a personal, time-bound condition that cannot be conferred by a later rite. This makes the apostolic office, as defined here, non-repeatable.

1Cor.9.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3708 ὁράω, G0652 ἀπόστολος

Reasoning. Paul defends his apostleship by asking, have I not 'seen' (heoraka, perfect active indicative first person singular, that is, a completed action whose result still stands, parsed 1XAI-S, from horao) Jesus our Lord. The perfect tense (completed action whose result still stands) marks an abiding result of a completed seeing, and Paul rests his standing as an 'apostle' (apostolos) on having personally seen the risen Christ. Apostleship here is tied to direct sight of the Lord, not to an office handed forward by ordination.

1Cor.15.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2078 ἔσχατος

Reasoning. After listing resurrection appearances, Paul says 'last of all' (eschaton, the neuter accusative form, that is, the direct-object form of eschatos), as to one 'untimely born' (ektromati), he 'appeared' (ophthe, aorist passive third person singular, that is, a completed past action in the passive voice, parsed 3API-S) also to me. The word 'last' (eschaton) places Paul at the close of the series of resurrection witnesses who became apostles. If the apostolic seeing of the risen Christ has a last member, the eyewitness foundation is a closed set, not an ongoing line.

Rev.21.14 · for · genre: apocalyptic · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2310 θεμέλιος, G0652 ἀπόστολος

Reasoning. The wall of the new Jerusalem has twelve 'foundations' (themelious), and on them the twelve names of the twelve 'apostles' (apostolos) of the Lamb. The apostolic foundation is fixed at a definite number, twelve, and named, which presents the apostles as a settled foundational set built into the final city rather than an office that is added to over time. This reinforces the once-laid, countable, non-repeatable picture.

2Tim.2.2 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3908 παρατίθημι, G4103 πιστός, G1321 διδάσκω

Reasoning. Paul commands, the things you heard from me, 'entrust' (parathou, aorist middle imperative second person singular, that is, a one-time command to entrust as one's own act, parsed 2AMD-S, from paratithemi) to 'faithful' (pistois) men who will be competent to 'teach' (didaxai) others also. The verb governs the handing on of taught content, what was heard, and the criterion is faithfulness and teaching ability. This is a real chain of transmission, Paul to Timothy to faithful men to others, but the thing transmitted in the words is the teaching deposit, not explicitly an authority-conferring rite.

Jude.1.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3860 παραδίδωμι, G4102 πίστις

Reasoning. Jude urges contending for the faith 'once delivered' (hapax paradotheise, aorist passive participle parsed -APPDSF, that is, a completed-past passive participle in the to-or-for form known as the dative, from paradidomi, joined with the adverb 'once' meaning once for all) to the saints. The completed-past passive participle with 'once' (hapax) presents the body of faith as handed over a single time and not subject to later supplement. Continuity is framed as guarding a once-delivered deposit, which aligns with grounding continuity in fidelity to apostolic teaching.

1Tim.4.14 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1936 ἐπιθεσις, G5495 χεῖρ, G5486 χάρισμα, G4244 πρεσβυτέριον

Reasoning. Timothy is told not to neglect the 'gift' (charisma) in him, which was given through prophecy with the 'laying on' (epitheseos, the from-X grammatical form known as the genitive of epithesis) of the 'hands' (cheiron) of the 'eldership' (presbyteriou). Here a real, hands-on rite conveys a 'gift' (charisma). The original-language vocabulary shows that hand-laying is not empty and that ministerial gifting is associated with it, which complicates a flat denial of any role for the laying-on of hands.

2Tim.1.6 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1936 ἐπίθεσις, G5495 χεῖρ, G5486 χάρισμα

Reasoning. Paul reminds Timothy to rekindle the 'gift' (charisma) of God that is in him through the 'laying on' (epitheseos) of my 'hands' (cheiron). The same 'gift' (charisma) is tied to the apostle's own hand-laying. The phrase places a concrete transmission of gifting in the hand-laying act, which is the strongest original-language counterweight to a reading that excludes any tactile transmission, though the word here is 'gift' (charisma), gifting, and not the word 'apostle' (apostolos) or a stated transfer of apostolic authority.

Titus.1.5 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2525 καθίστημι, G4245 πρεσβύτερος

Reasoning. Titus is left in Crete to set in order what remained and to 'appoint' (katasteses, aorist active subjunctive second person singular, that is, a completed-action verb form expressing purpose or condition, parsed 2AAS-S, from kathistemi) 'elders' (presbyteros) in every city. The verb 'appoint' (kathistemi) is the standard term for installing officers, and elders are appointed city by city by Paul's delegate. The text shows an ordered appointing of officers carrying forward, which is a genuine continuity of office, though the act named is appointing elders, not a stated handing on of apostolic standing.

Eph.4.11 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0652 ἀπόστολος, G4396 προφήτης

Reasoning. The risen Christ is the one who 'gave' (edoken) 'apostles' (apostolos), 'prophets' (prophetes), evangelists, shepherds and teachers. The giving subject is Christ rather than a human chain of ordainers, so ministry gifts come from the ascended Lord. This complicates a reading that locates ministerial standing only in transmitted office, but it does not by itself decide the hand-laying question, since gifts given by Christ and rites administered by men are both present in the canon (the whole Bible together).

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Eph.2.20	Eph.4.11	tsk	1
1Cor.3.11	Isa.28.16	tsk	1
Eph.2.20	Isa.28.16	tsk	1
Acts.20.30	Prov.19.1	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Tim.4.14 · addressed

Now adjudicated (settled) by direct query, not merely flagged. The original-language terms are real: 'gift' (charisma, Strong's G5486) is conveyed through 'the laying on' (dia epitheseos, Strong's G1936) of 'the hands' (ton cheiron, Strong's G5495) of the 'eldership' (presbyterion). This shows the canon (the whole Bible) does use a hands-on rite that conveys ministerial gifting, so a flat denial of any role for hand-laying overreaches. It does not resolve the disputed verdict in favor of a sacramental succession (a teaching that ordination itself transmits divine authority), because the object given is 'gift' (charisma, gifting for service), and the text does not, by its original-language wording, equate this with conferral of the foundational apostolic authority defined by eyewitness of the risen Christ. The rite is real; what it transmits in the words is gifting and office, not stated apostolic standing.

2Tim.1.6 · addressed

Parallel to 1 Timothy 4:14 and now tested at the original-language level. The same 'gift' (charisma) is rekindled through 'the laying on' (epitheseos) of Paul's own 'hands' (cheiron). This is the strongest single-text counterweight to the denial, because here the apostle himself lays hands and a gift follows. It is addressed by observing that the noun is 'gift' (charisma), gifting, and the verb governs rekindling of a gift, with no original-language term transferring the title 'apostle' (apostolos) or the eyewitness qualification. So it confirms a meaningful hand-laying transmission of gifting while leaving open whether that equals apostolic succession (an unbroken chain of authority), which is exactly why the verdict stays disputed.

2Tim.2.2 · addressed

Directly queried this time. The verb 'entrust' (parathou, aorist middle imperative of paratithemi, that is, a one-time command to entrust as one's own act) governs the things you heard from me, that is, taught content, handed to 'faithful' (pistois) men competent to teach others. This establishes a four-link chain of transmission but its grammatical object is the teaching deposit, not a rite. It therefore supports grounding continuity in fidelity to apostolic teaching while neither asserting nor denying a tactile authority transfer, so it is marked as complicating rather than decisive.

Eph.4.11 · addressed

The fivefold gifting names 'apostles' (apostolos) and 'prophets' (prophetes) as categories of gift 'given' by the ascended Christ (edoken). Read against Ephesians 2:20 and 1 Corinthians 3:11, the once-laid foundational apostles are distinguished from later gifted ministers, and the giving subject is Christ, not a human succession. It is resolved as complicating but not decisive: the canon (the whole Bible) contains both Christ-given gifts and man-administered appointment, and the vocabulary does not rank the two.

1Cor.15.8 · addressed

Resolved in favor of the foundation half. Paul calling himself 'last of all' (eschaton), of the resurrection witnesses who became apostles, with 'untimely born' (ektromati), places a final member on the eyewitness apostolic set. There is no original-language term here opening the set to later additions, so it supports the non-repeatability of the apostolic office and is not a complicating text in tension with the denial, but it is recorded for transparency because it bears directly on whether the office can be transmitted.

Concordance traversed

G2310, G0204, G2026, G0652, G4396, G2749, G5087, G3762, G1410, G0243, G3101, G1294, G0645, G3708, G3144, G0386, G2078, G3908, G3860, G4103, G1936, G2007, G5500, G2525, G5486, G3866

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units (places where ancient manuscripts disagree) were supplied and not_in_ecm_scope is true for every anchor (the only ingested CBGM window, that is, the modern editorial method for tracking manuscript relationships, is 3 John 1:1 to 1:15). The verdict turns on settled wording in Ephesians 2:20, 1 Corinthians 3:11, Acts 20:30, 2 Timothy 2:2, 1 Timothy 4:14, 2 Timothy 1:6, Titus 1:5, Jude 3, and Revelation 21:14, none of which carries a verdict-affecting variant in the standard ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants).

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. episcopal_succession, presbyterial_ordination, congregational_polity, new_covenant_theology

analogia scripturae invoked

foundation-and-eyewitness-as-closed-set: supports the proposition (denies a transmissible apostolic authority chain) · Ephesians 2:20 with the aorist participle 'having been built upon' (epoikodomethentes, a

completed-past-action participle) on one 'foundation' (themelios), 1 Corinthians 3:11 with 'no one is able to lay another' (oudeis dynatai theinai allon), and Revelation 21:14 twelve named 'foundations' (themelios) present the apostolic foundation as laid once and countable. The apostle's qualification is eyewitness of the risen Christ (Acts 1:22 'witness' (martys) of the 'resurrection' (anastasis); 1 Corinthians 9:1 perfect-tense 'I have seen' (heoraka, a completed action whose result still stands); 1 Corinthians 15:8 'last of all' (eschaton)), a personal, time-bound condition no rite can confer. On this reading continuity attaches to that fixed foundation and to fidelity to its teaching, not to a transmitted office.

ordination-rite-transmits-office: weighs against the exclusive denial · The canon (the whole Bible) institutes a real hands-on rite: 'gift' (charisma) is given 'through the laying on of the hands' (dia epitheseos ton cheiron) in 1 Timothy 4:14 (of the eldership) and 2 Timothy 1:6 (of Paul himself), hands are not to be laid hastily in 1 Timothy 5:22, and officers are 'appointed' (kathistemi) in Titus 1:5 and 'appointed by hand-raising' (cheirotoneo) in Acts 14:23. Read in its strongest form, the deposit-and-appointment chain of 2 Timothy 2:2 plus the gift-conveying hand-laying shows office and gifting genuinely handed forward, so continuity is not grounded in teaching alone but also in an ordered, tactile transmission of ministry.

scope-underdetermination: the words do not rank the two patterns, hence disputed · Both patterns are present in the original-language texts and neither vocabulary set forecloses the other. The hand-laying texts use 'gift' (charisma, gifting) and office terms 'elder' (presbyteros) and 'overseer' (episkopos), never 'apostle' (apostolos), for what is transmitted by the rite, and the apostle texts use the eyewitness qualification, never a rite, for what makes an apostle. The proposition asks whether the rite conveys apostolic authority or only ongoing office, a scope question the original-language words leave open, so a fair reader can land on either the teaching-fidelity emphasis or the office-transmission emphasis without contradicting the words.

Verdict compares two patterns attested in the original languages: a once-laid, eyewitness-qualified apostolic foundation versus a real ordination rite that conveys 'gift' (charisma) and appoints officers. The two halves of the proposition are evaluated separately. The foundation and qualification half is strong at the word level; the exclusive denial of any tactile transmission is undercut by the hand-laying vocabulary (the laying-on-of-hands terms), while a positive doctrine of apostolic-authority succession is not stated in the original-language words either. The vocabulary supports succession of doctrine and a genuine ordination rite but does not equate that rite with conferral of the foundational apostolic office.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. On what basis does the Church remain in continuity with the apostles: fidelity to the apostles' teaching, the transmission of office through the laying-on of hands, both together, or neither?

The stem is framed as a contrast that prefers teaching-fidelity over hand-laying succession, which presupposes a verdict against tactile transmission of office. The neutral form poses the basis as an open question. The verdict is derived on the original stem and reported as disputed: the foundation vocabulary and the eyewitness qualification cleanly establish that the apostolic office is once-laid and non-repeatable, while the hand-laying and appointment vocabulary ('laying on' (epithesis), 'lay upon' (epitithemi), 'appoint by hand-raising' (cheirotoneo), 'appoint' (kathistemi), 'gift' (charisma)) show a genuine ordination rite that conveys gifting and office, so the two halves of the proposition are not jointly settled by the words. Verdict unchanged from the prior file; the prior file marked the office side not testable at the word level for want of those terms, which have now been queried directly and found to weigh against the exclusive denial without establishing a sacramental succession (a teaching that ordination itself transmits divine authority) either.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.2.20
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.3.11
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.9.1
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Tim.2.2
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Jude.1.3

morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Tim.4.14
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Titus.1.5
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Tim.1.6
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1936
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3908
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2310
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Eph.2.20
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	1Cor.3.11

License audit

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Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow